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DEMOGRAPHIC ANALYSIS OF THE GCC COUNTRIES: DYNAMICS, STRUCTURE AND ECONOMIC IMPLICATIONS (2000–2026)

Abstract

This study presents a comprehensive analysis of demographic dynamics in the Gulf Cooperation Council (GCC) countries over the period 2000–2026. Based on statistical data from international organizations and regional statistical centers, key trends in population size, age-sex structure, and the ratio of citizens to foreign residents have been identified. Particular attention is paid to the impact of migration processes on the economic development of the region and to the structural challenges associated with a high dependence on foreign labor. A comparative analysis of the dynamics of total population and citizen population across the countries has revealed fundamental differences in the demographic development models of the GCC states.

1. Introduction

The countries of the Gulf Cooperation Council (GCC) represent a unique demographic phenomenon in global practice. As some of the world's fastest-growing economies due to vast hydrocarbon resources, they simultaneously demonstrate unprecedented population growth rates, which are almost entirely driven by the influx of foreign labor [1, 2]. This distinctive feature creates a complex set of economic, social, and political challenges that require in-depth analysis and balanced policy responses.

Over the period from 2000 to 2025, the total population of the GCC countries increased from 30.5 million to 62.8 million, representing a compound annual growth

rate of approximately 3.5%—nearly three times the global average [3, 4]. However, behind this outwardly impressive growth lie deep structural imbalances associated with

No	Year	Bahrain	Qatar	Kuwait	UAE	Oman	Saudi Arabia	Total GCC	SA Share, %
1	2000	0.6	0.6	2.2	3.5	2.4	20.5	29.8	68.8
2	2001	0.7	0.6	2.3	3.8	2.5	21.0	30.9	68.0
3	2002	0.7	0.7	2.4	4.0	2.5	21.5	31.8	67.6
4	2003	0.8	0.7	2.5	4.2	2.3	22.0	32.5	67.7
5	2004	0.8	0.8	2.8	4.3	2.4	22.6	33.7	67.1
6	2005	0.9	0.9	3.0	4.7	2.5	23.3	35.3	66.0
7	2006	1.0	1.0	3.2	5.0	2.6	24.1	36.9	65.3
8	2007	1.0	1.2	3.4	5.3	2.7	24.9	38.5	64.7
9	2008	1.1	1.4	3.4	5.5	2.9	25.8	40.1	64.3
10	2009	1.2	1.6	3.5	5.8	3.2	26.7	42.0	63.6
11	2010	1.2	1.7	3.6	8.3	2.8	27.6	45.2	61.1
12	2011	1.2	1.7	3.7	8.4	3.3	28.4	45.7	62.1
13	2012	1.2	1.8	3.8	8.5	3.6	29.2	48.1	60.7
14	2013	1.3	2.0	4.0	8.7	3.9	29.4	49.3	59.6
15	2014	1.3	2.2	4.1	8.8	4.0	30.0	50.4	59.5
16	2015	1.4	2.4	4.2	8.9	4.2	30.9	52.0	59.4
17	2016	1.4	2.6	4.4	9.1	4.4	31.8	53.7	59.2
18	2017	1.5	2.7	4.5	9.3	4.6	32.6	55.2	59.1
19	2018	1.5	2.8	4.6	9.4	4.6	33.4	56.3	59.3
20	2019	1.5	2.8	4.8	9.5	4.6	34.2	57.4	59.6
21	2020	1.5	2.8	4.7	9.4	4.5	35.0	57.9	60.4
22	2021	1.5	2.7	4.4	9.6*	4.5	34.1	56.8	60.0
23	2022	1.5	2.8	4.8	9.8	5.1	33.9	57.9	58.5

24	2023	1.6	2.9	4.9	10.7	5.1	34.4	59.6	57.7
25	2024	1.6	3.0	5.0	11.2	5.2	34.5	60.5	57.0
26	2025	1.6	3.1	5.0	11.3	5.3	35.3	61.6	57.3
27	2026 (прогноз)	1.7	3.2	5.1	11.6	5.7	37.0	64.3	57.5

The dominance of the migration component, gender disparities, and a high degree of economic dependence on foreign labor resources [1, 5].

The present study, based on three datasets—total population dynamics, citizen population, and forecast estimates—provides a comprehensive analysis of demographic processes in the region, identifies their underlying causes, and assesses their long-term economic implications.

2. Analysis of Total Population Dynamics in the GCC Countries

2.1. Scale and Growth Rates

The total population of the GCC countries demonstrated impressive growth over the analyzed period, increasing from 30.5 million in 2000 to 62.8 million in 2025, representing more than a twofold increase [4]. At the same time, growth rates were highly uneven both across different periods and among individual countries.

Table 1. Dynamics of Total Population in the GCC Countries (2000–2026), million persons

***** — estimate based on linear interpolation of data for 2020 and 2022.

****** — Abnormal fluctuations in population size during 2020–2022 are associated with the consequences of the COVID-19 pandemic (see Section 2.2 for details).

Sources: [6, 7, 8, 9, 10].

Based on the data from Table 1, Figures 1, 2, and 3 have been constructed and are presented below.

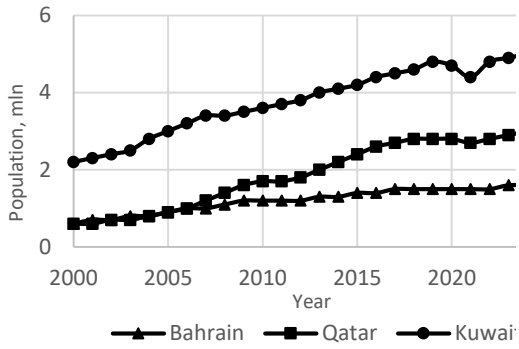


Fig. 1. Dynamics of Population in the GCC Countries, million persons

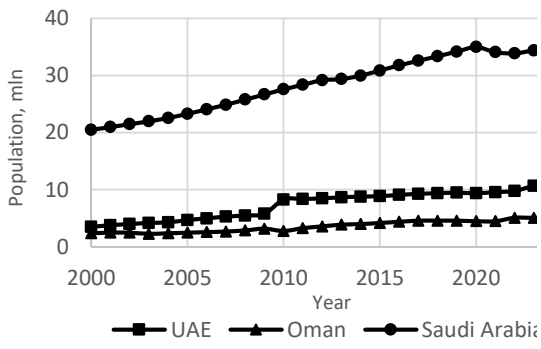


Fig. 2. Dynamics of Population in the GCC Countries, million persons

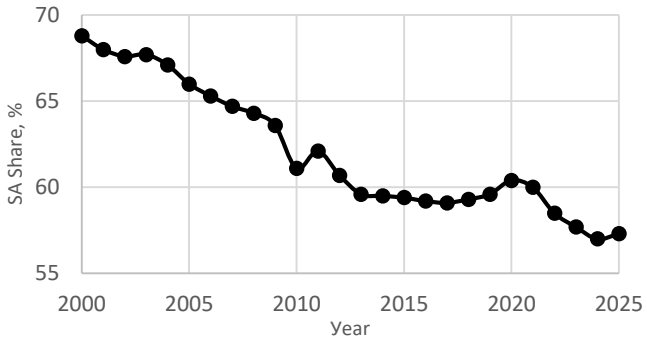


Fig. 3. Dynamics of Saudi Arabia's Share, %

Leading Positions in Growth Rates:

Qatar demonstrates the most impressive dynamics, with its population increasing by 423% over 25 years—from 0.6 to 3.1 million persons. This is one of the highest rates in the world [3]. The main growth occurred during 2004–2014, which is associated with large-scale infrastructure projects, including preparations for the 2022 FIFA World Cup.

The United Arab Emirates ranks second with a population increase of 250% (from 3.5 to 11.3 million persons) [11]. The transformation of the UAE from a regional trading center into a global financial and tourism hub has ensured a steady influx of foreign specialists and workers.

Bahrain (+154%), Kuwait (+139%), and Oman (+129%) also rank among the ten countries with the highest population growth rates in the world [3]. At the same time, growth rates in Oman were more balanced due to the relatively high share of the citizen population.

Saudi Arabia, possessing the largest population in the region (35.3 million in 2025), demonstrated more moderate growth rates (+72% over 25 years) compared to Qatar (+423%) and the UAE (+250%) [3]. This is explained by the targeted policy of citizen employment (Saudization) and restrictions on the import of foreign labor [1]. A logical result was the decline in the kingdom's share in the total GCC population from 68.8% in 2000 to 57.3% in 2025 (the last column of Table 1). Thus, although Saudi Arabia remains the demographic core of the region, other GCC countries are increasing their presence faster, primarily due to more intensive migration inflows. According to forecasts for 2026, Saudi Arabia's share is projected at 57.5% [10].

2.2. Volatility and External Shocks

The analysis of annual growth rates reveals a high sensitivity of demographic dynamics to external factors:

The period 2003–2008 was characterized by peak population growth rates (up to 18.9% in Qatar in 2008), driven by record oil prices and large-scale investments in infrastructure projects [4]. During these years, a massive influx of foreign labor was observed to implement ambitious development plans.

The 2009 crisis led to a slowdown in growth rates due to falling oil prices and the scaling down of certain investment projects [5].

The COVID-19 pandemic (2020–2021) became the most severe demographic shock for the region. For the first time in decades, some countries experienced an absolute population decline [10]:

- UAE: population decreased by 2.3% in 2020;
- Kuwait: decline of 2.2% in 2020 and 6.1% in 2021;
- Oman: decrease of 3.0% in 2020;
- Saudi Arabia: decline of 2.6% in 2021.

This was caused by the mass outflow of foreign workers to their countries of origin amid border closures and the contraction of economic activity [10].

Post-pandemic recovery (2022–2025) demonstrates a confident return to growth. In 2024, the population of the GCC countries grew by 3.6% (by more than 2.1 million

persons) compared to 2023, indicating a full recovery from the demographic downturn of the pandemic period [4]. The cumulative increase since 2021 amounted to approximately 7.6 million persons [8].

3. Structural Analysis: Citizens and Foreign Residents

3.1. Fundamental Imbalances

The most significant feature of the demographic structure of the GCC countries is the stark divergence between the growth rates of the total population and those of the citizen population. While the total population grew at a compound annual rate of 3.5%, the citizen population increased by only 2.1% per year [1]. This reflects the region's fundamental dependence on labor imports.

Table 2. Ratio of Citizens to Foreign Residents in the GCC Countries (2024)

No	Country	Total population, million persons	Share of citizens, %	Share of foreign residents, %
1	Qatar	3.0	~12	~88
2	UAE	11.2	~13	~87
3	Kuwait	5.0	~32	~68
4	Bahrain	1.6	~47	~53
5	Saudi Arabia	34.5	~56	~44
6	Oman	5.2	~57	~43

Sources: [9, 10, 12].

In Qatar and the UAE, the share of foreign residents reaches 87–88% of the total population [9]. This means that the citizen population in these countries accounts for no more than 12–13%—a unique situation in global practice with no parallels among other labor-importing countries [2].

In Kuwait, the share of citizens is approximately 32%, and in Bahrain—about 47%. The most balanced structure is observed in Saudi Arabia and Oman, where the share of citizens exceeds 55% [12].

3.2. Dynamics of the Citizen Population

For understanding the true demographic processes, it is critical to analyze specifically the citizen population, as it is this group that determines the long-term social and economic obligations of the states.

Table 3. Dynamics of the citizen population and its growth rates in the GCC countries (thousand persons, %)

No	Year	Bahrain	%*	Kuwait	%*	Oman	%*	Saudi Arabia	%*
1	2000	398.2	—	841.8	—	1777.7	—	14905.3	—
2	2001	409.6	2.9	870.3	3.4	1826.1	2.7	15275.7	2.5
3	2002	427.2	4.3	898.3	3.2	1869.6	2.4	15655.3	2.5
4	2003	445.6	4.3	927.7	3.3	1781.6	-4.7	16044.4	2.5
5	2004	464.8	4.3	956.2	3.1	1802.9	1.2	16444.0	2.5
6	2005	484.8	4.3	992.2	3.8	1842.7	2.2	16854.2	2.5
7	2006	505.7	4.3	1023.3	3.1	1883.6	2.2	17270.2	2.5
8	2007	527.4	4.3	1054.6	3.1	1922.7	2.1	17691.3	2.4
9	2008	541.6	2.7	1087.6	3.1	1967.2	2.3	18115.6	2.4
10	2009	558.0	3.0	1118.9	2.9	2017.6	2.6	18543.2	2.4
11	2010	570.7	2.3	1148.4	2.6	1957.3	-3.0	18973.6	2.3
12	2011	584.7	2.5	1183.2	3.0	2013.2	2.9	19405.7	2.3
13	2012	599.6	2.6	1212.4	2.5	2092.6	3.9	19838.4	2.2
14	2013	614.8	2.5	1242.5	2.5	2172.0	3.8	19209.8	-3.2
15	2014	630.7	2.6	1275.9	2.7	2260.7	4.1	19312.7	0.5
16	2015	647.8	2.7	1307.6	2.5	2344.9	3.7	19692.6	2.0
17	2016	664.7	2.6	1337.7	2.3	2427.8	3.5	20081.6	2.0
18	2017	677.5	1.9	1370.0	2.4	2505.4	3.2	20427.6	1.7
19	2018	689.7	1.8	1403.1	2.4	2579.2	2.9	20768.6	1.7
20	2019	701.8	1.8	1432.0	2.1	2655.1	2.9	21103.2	1.6
21	2020	713.3	1.6	1460.0	2.0	2622.5	-1.2	21430.1	1.5
22	2021	719.3	0.9	1488.7	2.0	2766.8	5.5	21690.6	1.2

23	2022	721.7	0.3	1517.1	1.9	2833.7	2.4	18792.3	-13.4
24	2023	727.4	0.8	1545.8	1.9	2892.0	2.1	19245.9	2.4
25	2024	739.7	1.7	1566.2	1.3	2955.2	2.2	19635.3	2.0

***** — annual growth rate.

Based on the data from Table 3, Fig. 4 and Fig. 5 were constructed.

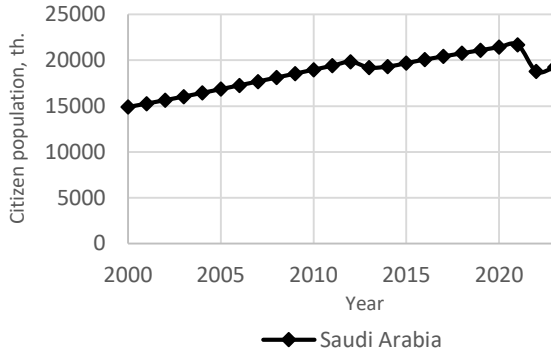


Fig. 4. Dynamics of the citizen population of Saudi Arabia, thousand persons

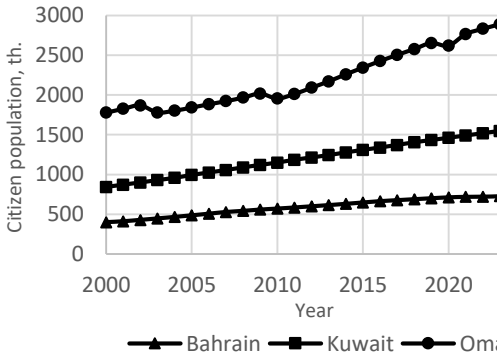


Fig. 5. Dynamics of the citizen population of Bahrain, Kuwait, and Oman, thousand persons

Note: Table 3 presents data only for those GCC countries that publish official population breakdowns by citizenship. Qatar and the United Arab Emirates do not disclose official statistics on the number of their citizens, which is why they are absent from this table. All existing estimates for these countries (e.g., the share of citizens at approximately 12% in Qatar and 13% in the UAE) are calculated figures without official verification and, therefore, have not been included in this analysis.

Sources: [3, 13].

Key Patterns in Citizen Population Dynamics:

1. **Stable growth rates:** Unlike the total population, the growth of the citizen population in all countries remains relatively stable at 2–3% per year. In Bahrain, peak values (up to 4.3%) were observed in the early 2000s, but the rates subsequently stabilized at 1.5–2.5% [6].

2. **Natural increase as the primary driver:** The growth of the citizen population is driven primarily by natural increase (births) and, to a much lesser extent, by naturalization, which is extremely limited in the GCC countries [1].

3. **Resilience to external shocks:** Unlike the total population, the number of citizens was virtually unaffected by the COVID-19 pandemic, whereas the total population in several countries declined by 5–6% [10].

Note: Table 3 records an anomalous decline in the citizen population of Saudi Arabia from 21.7 million in 2021 to 18.8 million in 2022 (a decrease of 13.4%, or 2.9 million persons). A similar, albeit less extensive, adjustment was previously observed in 2013 (a 3.2% decrease). These fluctuations are not caused by an actual demographic decline, which is biologically impossible for such a population, but rather by a methodological recalculation (retrospective updating) of data by the General Authority for Statistics (GASTAT) of Saudi Arabia. This recalculation was conducted following the first comprehensive national population census in 2022 in a long time, aimed at eliminating accumulated errors from previous years' estimation models, including duplicate records and outdated data in civil registries [6, 14, 15].

4. Age-Sex Structure of the Population

4.1. Gender Imbalance

One of the most striking features of the demographic situation in the GCC is the extremely pronounced gender imbalance. According to GCC-Stat data for 2024, the region has 169 men per 100 women, which significantly exceeds the global average (101 men per 100 women) [12].

Causes of the imbalance:

- The influx of labor migrants employed predominantly in traditionally "male" economic sectors—construction, energy, industry, and transportation [2];
- In countries with the highest share of foreign residents (Qatar, UAE, Kuwait), the imbalance is particularly acute;
- According to GCC-Stat, men account for 62.8% of the total population (38.5 million), while women represent only 37.2% (22.7 million) [11].

Economic consequences:

- Development of specialized infrastructure for a predominantly male population (dormitories, labor camps);
- Formation of a stable outflow of remittances from the region to labor-sending countries [2];

- Limited female participation in economic activity, which reduces productivity growth potential.

4.2. Age Structure and Dependency Ratio

According to GCC-Stat data for 2024, the age structure of the GCC population has the following characteristics [7]:

- Working-age population (15–64 years): 76.7%—the highest value among all world regions, creating exceptionally favorable conditions for economic growth;
- Children (0–14 years): 20.6%;
- Elderly (65 years and older): 2.6%—an extremely low figure reflecting the young age profile of migrants.

Youth (15–34 years) accounts for 38.2% of the total population, or 23.5 million persons [7]. According to UN projections, by 2050 the youth population in the region will reach 28.6 million, requiring the creation of an additional 5.9 million jobs [9].

The dependency ratio stands at only 30.4 dependents per 100 working-age persons (27 children and 3.4 elderly), significantly below the global average [7]. This creates a "demographic dividend" — a unique opportunity for accelerated economic growth that can be realized under the condition of effective utilization of labor potential.

5. Migration Processes as the Primary Driver of Demographic Dynamics

5.1. Scale and Structure of Labor Migration

As of 2024, approximately 25 million labor migrants reside in the GCC countries, accounting for more than 40% of the total population [12]. The main source countries are South Asian states (India, Pakistan, Bangladesh, Sri Lanka, Nepal), as well as Egypt, the Philippines, and other Southeast Asian countries [5].

Labor force dynamics: Between 2021 and 2025, the labor force in the region increased from 27.7 million to 37.1 million persons, representing a growth of 34.1% (9.4 million new workers) [8].

Growth rates by category [8]:

- Foreign labor force: +9.1% annually on average;
- National citizens: +4.4% annually on average;

- The share of foreign labor force constitutes 66.5% of the total employed population.

5.2. Sectoral Structure of Employment

The largest concentration of foreign workers is found in the following sectors [8]:

- Services sector: 38.8% of the total labor force;
- Construction: 19.8%;
- Domestic work: 17.4%;
- Trade and industry: 22.3%.

5.3. Institutional Framework of Migration Policy

The system of labor migration regulation in the GCC countries has several characteristic features [5]:

1. **The Kafala system (sponsorship):** The key regulatory institution that binds migrants to employers and limits their autonomy;
2. **Absence of integration policies:** Migration is viewed as a temporary phenomenon, which hinders the development of long-term adaptation mechanisms for migrants;
3. **Strict regulation:** GCC countries use migration policy as an economic-political instrument of "soft power" [5].

***** — The Kafala system is a system of financial support, guarantee, and sponsorship, i.e., an employment system that emerged in the 1950s. It is the primary system for regulating relations with labor migrants in Muslim countries of the Middle East (particularly Saudi Arabia, UAE, Qatar, Bahrain, Iraq, Jordan). In labor relations, Kafala is based on tying the residence permit of a foreign worker to a specific employer, who controls the worker's personal documents and makes decisions regarding the possibility of their return to their home country.

6. Forecast Estimates and Long-Term Challenges

According to projections by the UN and GCC-Stat, the total population of the GCC countries will continue to grow and reach 83.6 million by 2050 (an increase of 33.6% compared to 2025) [9]. At the same time, the following trends are expected [9]:

- Doubling of the elderly population (over 65 years) to 5.5 million persons;
- Urbanization reaching 90% (compared to 82% in 2024);

- Maintenance of a high share of foreign labor, although countries are actively implementing workforce nationalization programs.

Priority Areas of Demographic Policy [1, 2, 9]

In response to the identified demographic imbalances, the authorities of the GCC countries are gradually transitioning from passive migration management to active policies aimed at balancing the labor market and social structure. Priority areas include:

1. Transformation of the Kafala system amid growing demands for migrant rights and the need to maintain economic competitiveness;
2. Implementation of workforce nationalization policies while maintaining the demand for foreign labor;
3. Integration of youth into the labor market—creation of 28.6 million jobs for young people by 2050;
4. Mitigation of gender imbalance and ensuring social stability amid persistent sex ratio disparities;
5. Enhancing resilience to global shocks such as climate change or structural energy transition.

CONCLUSION

(Summarizing the analytical section: historical dynamics 2000–2026)

The analysis of demographic dynamics in the GCC countries over 2000–2026 reveals a fundamental duality: impressive growth of the total population (more than doubling over 25 years) alongside deep structural imbalances caused by the dominance of the migration component. The Gulf countries have formed a unique model of economic development based on large-scale labor imports, which led to the creation of a regional labor market where foreign workers account for up to 87–88% of the population in certain countries [16, 17].

At the same time, the citizen population grows at relatively slow and stable rates (2–3% per year), creating a gap between the demographic and social structure of the region [18]. Of particular importance for understanding the challenges are age and gender imbalances: an exceptionally young structure with a low dependency ratio

(76.7% working-age population) creates conditions for realizing a "demographic dividend," yet the extreme gender imbalance (169 men per 100 women) indicates a massive social shift [19, 20].

Thus, the historical demographic development of the GCC countries in the 21st century represents a unique case where economic success based on hydrocarbon resources has led to the formation of structural imbalances requiring a new approach to human capital and migration management.

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